

1 Inheritance Trends

1.1 Introduction to the Inheritance Trends Section

The Inheritance Trends section presents a comprehensive compilation of cross-national time-series data on the annual flow of wealth transfers, that is, the wealth passed from one household or individual to another either at the time of the donor's death (bequests) or while the donor is alive (inter vivos gifts). This section contains estimates of the size of these flows, expressed both in national currency and relative to national income, as estimated in the existing literature using fiscal records or an ensemble of data sources. It also documents the average effective rate at which these transfers are taxed. The data are accompanied by Methodological Tables that provide systematic assessments of the underlying concepts, methods, and sources used to produce each series.

The Inheritance Trends section is not about the distribution of wealth across the population: every estimate refers to the reference population as a whole. What it measures instead is the *magnitude* of the annual transmission of wealth between generations and its evolution over time. This distinction matters because inheritance flows are a macroeconomic quantity: they can be compared to national income, they can be traced back over long historical horizons, and they can be related to the tax revenue they generate.

The core value-added of this section is to assemble, for the very first time in a single venue, estimates that are otherwise scattered across national historical studies, each built on different records and conventions, and to make explicit whether a given estimate derives from fiscal data or from an ensemble of data sources such as national accounts.

1.2 The Structure of the Inheritance Trends Section

In the Inheritance Trends database, each estimate (**value**) is uniquely identified by the combination of the reference country indexed by a two-digit identifier (**GEO**), the reference year (**year**), the data source (**source**), and the **varcode**.

Table 1 provides a small extract from the Inheritance Trends database. This table displays data for Italy in 1995 and 1996. The series reported in the **value** column correspond to an inheritance indicator (**varcode**), with the **percentile** column always set to *p0p100* because all estimates in this section refer to the reference population as a whole. The **varcode** column carries the substantive information: the type of measure (an aggregate in national currency, or a ratio to national income), the concept it refers to (bequests only, or bequests and gifts together), and the type of flow estimate (fiscal or economic). The subsequent sections elaborate on the **varcode** and on the **percentile** variable.

1.3 The varcode in the Inheritance Trends Section

In the Inheritance Trends section, two of the five elements of **varcode** are fixed across the entire database. The constant elements are the first, that identifies the Section of the GC Wealth Project and takes the value **i**, and the second, that indexes the household sector and takes the value **hs**. The **Variable Type**, the **Concept**, and the **Section-Specific** parts of the **varcode** vary within a source and across sources and are explained in detail in what follows. Hence, **varcode** takes the following form:

$$\underbrace{i}_{\text{Section}} - \underbrace{hs}_{\text{Sector}} - \underbrace{CCC}_{\text{Variable Type}} - \underbrace{DDDDDD}_{\text{Concept}} - \underbrace{ZZ}_{\text{Section-Specific}}$$

Table 1: Introducing the GC Inheritance Trends Database - Snippet

source	GEO	GEO_long	year	varcode	percentile	value
Acciari2021	IT	Italy	1995	i-hs-agg-etnwea-ff	p0p100	5.575000e+10
Guzzardi2026	IT	Italy	1995	i-hs-agg-etnweg-ef	p0p100	6.223423e+10
Acciari2021	IT	Italy	1995	i-hs-agg-etnweg-ff	p0p100	6.950000e+10
Guzzardi2026	IT	Italy	1995	i-hs-rat-averat-ef	p0p100	9.400000e-03
Acciari2021	IT	Italy	1995	i-hs-rto-etnwea-ff	p0p100	6.720000e-02
Guzzardi2026	IT	Italy	1995	i-hs-rto-etnweg-ef	p0p100	7.420000e-02
Gabbuti2025	IT	Italy	1995	i-hs-rto-etnweg-ff	p0p100	7.730000e-02
Acciari2021	IT	Italy	1995	i-hs-rto-etnweg-ff	p0p100	8.380000e-02
Acciari2021	IT	Italy	1996	i-hs-agg-etnwea-ff	p0p100	6.077000e+10
Guzzardi2026	IT	Italy	1996	i-hs-agg-etnweg-ef	p0p100	6.818048e+10
Acciari2021	IT	Italy	1996	i-hs-agg-etnweg-ff	p0p100	7.576000e+10
Guzzardi2026	IT	Italy	1996	i-hs-rat-averat-ef	p0p100	1.030000e-02
Acciari2021	IT	Italy	1996	i-hs-rto-etnwea-ff	p0p100	6.890000e-02
Guzzardi2026	IT	Italy	1996	i-hs-rto-etnweg-ef	p0p100	7.660000e-02
Acciari2021	IT	Italy	1996	i-hs-rto-etnweg-ff	p0p100	8.590000e-02
Gabbuti2025	IT	Italy	1996	i-hs-rto-etnweg-ff	p0p100	7.910000e-02

Table 2: Inheritance Trends: Variable Type

Code	Label	Description
rat	Rate	In general, a rate is expressed as a percentage. For instance, the marginal inheritance tax rate is the amount of tax that is paid on an additional dollar of inheritance received. It represents the rate at which a person's tax liability increases as their inheritance increases. The concept can also be applied to the saving rate which refers to the percentage of disposable income that is saved or not spent on consumption.
rto	Ratio	A ratio describes the relationship between two quantities and is expressed as the quotient of one quantity divided by another. For example, if a country's total private net wealth is €10,000 billion and its total national income is €2,000 billion, the ratio of private wealth to national income is 5 to 1, as total private wealth is five times the amount of national income.
agg	Aggregate	Aggregate value for a given institutional sector. The value is reported without knowing whether transactions that occur between units within the same sector are eliminated or kept during the aggregation.

1.3.1 Variable Type

The third element of the **varcode** identifies the broad type of measure. Table 2 provides the permitted strings of the **Variable Type** within the **varcode** in the Inheritance Trends database, together with a label and a description. The section employs three types of measure. Aggregates (**agg**) report the total annual flow of wealth transfers of the household sector; monetary values are always shown in national currency, in nominal terms, with no adjustment for inflation. Where the national currency changed over the period covered by a series, the whole series is expressed in the currency currently in force: for euro-area countries, for instance, values referring to years before the changeover are reported in euros rather than in the legacy national currency, so that a series is expressed in a single unit over its entire length. Ratios (**rto**) express the same annual flow relative to national income, which is the standard way of assessing the macroeconomic importance of inheritance and the only form in which the series can be compared across countries and across centuries. Rates (**rat**) report the average effective tax rate applied to the flow.

1.3.2 Concept

The fourth element of the **varcode** identifies the **Concept**. In the Inheritance Trends database, a concept is the object being measured: either the type of wealth transfer the flow estimate refers to, or the effective tax rate levied on that transfer. Table 3 reports the concepts and the corresponding identifiers used in the **varcode** of the Inheritance Trends database, together with a detailed description and the list of available **Variable Type** associated with each concept.

Two transfer concepts are distinguished. Inheritances (**etnwea**) cover wealth left at death only. Inheritances & Gifts (**etnweg**) cover wealth left at death together with inter vivos gifts and donations, and is the broader and more widely available of the two. Keeping them separate is essential: in countries where gifts are a common way of anticipating a bequest, the two concepts can differ substantially, and a comparison across countries that mixed them would be misleading. Wherever a source allows it, we publish both, so that users can gauge the size of the gift component directly. The third concept, the average effective tax rate (**averat**), is defined as the ratio between official wealth-transfer tax revenue and the estimated total tax base, that is, total estate, inheritance, and gift (EIG) tax revenue divided by the total flow of inheritances and gifts in a given year. It therefore measures the share of the annual flow of wealth transfers that is actually collected in taxes, and it is not a statutory rate: it reflects jointly the tax schedule in force, the exemptions and reliefs granted, and the extent to which transfers are declared at all.

Table 3: Inheritance Trends: Concept Dictionary

Code	Label	Description	Var Type
etnweg	Inheritances & Gifts	Inheritances & Gifts refers to wealth left at death (bequests) and intervivos gifts and donations. The value refers to the value of all possessions, tangible and intangible assets left at death, and to the value of all assets donated in life.	agg, rto
etnwea	Inheritances	Inheritances refer to wealth left at death (bequests), namely the value of all possessions, tangible and intangible assets left at death.	agg, rto
averat	Average Effective Tax Rate	The average tax rate is computed as the ratio between official tax revenue and estimate total tax base (e.g. the average effective wealth transfers tax rate is computed as the total EIG tax revenue divided by the total flow of inheritances and gifts in a given year).	rat

Table 4: Inheritance Trends: Section-Specific

Code	Label	Description
ef	Economic Flow	Estimates from national accounts
ff	Fiscal Flow	Estimates from fiscal records

1.3.3 Section-Specific

In the Inheritance Trends database, the section-specific part of the `varcode` refers to the type of estimate from which the flow of wealth transfers is derived. The database distinguishes two types: the fiscal flow (**ff**) and the economic flow (**ef**). The list of permitted strings and a short description is provided in Table 4.

This distinction is the central methodological divide of the section, and it is the reason why two estimates for the same country and year may legitimately differ. What separates the two is the *primary source* on which the estimate rests, not the amount of work the authors put into it: both are the outcome of a research exercise, and neither is a raw figure lifted from a statistical table.

The **fiscal flow** is built on fiscal data: the estates, inheritances, and gifts reported to the tax authority, as recorded in estate tax returns, inheritance tax statistics, and successions registers. These records are the starting point rather than the final estimate. Taken as they stand, they capture only the transfers that are declared, and their coverage moves with the tax legislation in force, which changes over time and across countries: estates below the filing threshold, assets that are exempt or benefit from special reliefs, and transfers that go unreported are absent from the raw returns. Authors therefore adjust the fiscal material before arriving at a flow estimate — grossing up for non-filing estates, imputing the value of tax-exempt assets and of asset classes outside the scope of the tax, correcting for valuation rules that depart from market values, and reconstructing series across legislative breaks. The specific adjustments differ from source to source and are documented in the Methodological Table of each source.

The **economic flow** is instead built on an ensemble of macroeconomic and demographic data, chiefly national accounts, typically by combining aggregate household wealth with mortality rates and with the ratio between the average wealth of the deceased and the average wealth of the living. It aims at the full economic magnitude of the transfer, independently of what is declared for tax purposes, at the cost of relying on estimation assumptions that are, again, documented in the Methodological Tables of each source.

Neither measure dominates the other, and we publish both wherever they are available. The fiscal flow stays closer to observed transfers and is the natural benchmark when the object of interest is the tax base; the economic flow is the appropriate measure when the object of interest is the intergenerational transmission of wealth as a whole. Users should not compare a fiscal flow for one country with an economic flow for another.

1.4 The percentile variable in the Inheritance Trends Section

In addition to the `varcode`, values are indexed by the `percentile` variable, which identifies the segment of the population an estimate refers to. The Inheritance Trends section is not a distributional section: every series published here refers to the reference population as a whole, and the `percentile` variable therefore takes the single value *p0p100* throughout, as reported in Table 5. The variable is retained so that each estimate is fully identified by the same set of keys, and so that the population an estimate refers to is stated explicitly rather than left implicit. Extending the section with estimates of wealth transfers received by different segments of the distribution is an important direction for future releases of the GC Wealth Project.

Table 5: Inheritance Trends: Percentiles

Code	Label	Description
p0p100	Overall Population	Everyone in the reference population

1.5 Construction of the Inheritance Trends Section

The procedure used to construct the Inheritance Trends database proceeds in three steps. First, we identify the relevant sources and obtain the raw data. Second, we transform and harmonize the raw data to fit our standards in terms of format and structure. Third, we run a set of tests and append the source-specific estimates to the database. Concurrently, we develop and write a detailed **Methodological Table**.

1.5.1 Step 1: Identification and Classification of Sources

The starting point is the identification of relevant estimates of the annual flow of wealth transfers. In principle, such estimates can originate from different *types* of sources, including academic, government, and corporate research, as well as cross-national research and official statistics. Table 6 provides an overview of the permitted types of source.

Table 6: Inheritance Trends: Source Types

Label	Description
Cross-national official statistics	Cross-national data from official institutions, such as national accounts from central banks.
Cross-national official survey data	Cross-national survey data from official institutions, such as household finance surveys from national statistical offices.
Cross-national corporate research	Cross-national research published by corporate entities, such as private consultancy firms.
Cross-national academic research	Cross-national research published by academic institutions, such as an academic journal article.
Cross-national government research	Cross-national research published by government institutions, such as government-commissioned reports.
Official statistics	Data from official institutions, such as national accounts from a country's central bank.
Official survey data	Survey data from official institutions, such as household finance surveys from a country's national statistical office.
Corporate research	Research published by corporate entities, such as private consultancy firms.
Academic research	Research published by academic institutions, such as an academic journal article.

Government research	Research published by government institutions, such as government-commissioned reports.
Government legislation	The actual text of public legislation.
Government legislative info	Texts published by government institutions that provide descriptive information about public legislation, such as a government website explaining tax clauses.
Government documents	Other texts published by government institutions, such as tax documents, forms, or descriptive reports.

In practice, however, the sources of the Inheritance Trends section are exclusively academic research. There is no official statistic, national or cross-national, that publishes the annual flow of inheritances and gifts as such: the underlying fiscal records and national accounts exist, but the step from those records to a flow estimate is a research exercise, and it is performed in academic work. Each source is therefore a study, or a set of companion studies, that reconstructs the flow for one country over a long historical period, or, in the case of the cross-national source, for many countries over a shorter recent period.

Table 7 lists the sources currently included in the Inheritance Trends database, together with their country coverage, the period they span, and the `varcode` components they provide. The strong asymmetry visible in the table is a substantive feature of the field rather than an artifact of our selection: long historical series exist only for the small number of countries whose estate and inheritance tax records have been systematically exploited, whereas broad country coverage is available only for recent decades.

Table 7: Inheritance Trends: Sources and Coverage

Source	Legend	Countries	Period	Concepts	Flow	Obs.
Guzzardi2026	Guzzardi and Morelli (2026)	63	1995-2024	averat, etnweg	ef	4842
Acciari2021	Acciari et al. (2020)	1	1995-2016	etnwea, etnweg	ff	88
Alvaredo2017	Alvaredo et al. (2017)	1	1870-2013	etnweg	ef	144
Apostel2025	Apostel (2025)	1	2009-2022	etnwea, etnweg	ff	24
Atkinson2012	Atkinson (2018)	1	1896-2008	etnwea, etnweg	ff	404
Brulhart2018	Brülhart et al. (2018)	1	1911-2011	etnweg	ef	9
Brulhart2026	Brülhart et al. (2026)	1	2002-2021	etnwea, etnweg	ff	40
Gabbuti2025	Gabbuti and Morelli (2025)	1	1864-2016	etnweg	ff	65
Piketty2011	Piketty (2011)	1	1826-2008	etnwea, etnweg	ef, ff	848
Schinke2012	-	1	1911-2009	etnweg	ef	7

Once the relevant source is identified and correctly classified, we acquire the raw data. For the Inheritance Trends section we do not produce our own estimates from micro data: the published estimates are used as they are made available by the authors, whether in the article itself, in its appendix, or in the replication material accompanying it. Where the authors publish several variants of the same series, we retain a single one, as described in Step 2.

1.5.2 Step 2: Transformation and Harmonization of Raw Data

The published raw data may come in various shapes or formats, including .pdf documents, and .xlsx or .csv files. Therefore, we need to process this information and harmonize the source-specific series to conform to our formatting standards. This involves assigning each data point (`value`) with relevant information, including its data source (`source`), reference year (`year`), country code (`GEO`, `GEO_long`), type of measure (`varcode`), and the reference population (`percentile`, always *p0p100* in this section). This procedure ensures a consistent data structure across all sources.

Two harmonization choices deserve to be made explicit. First, a source may publish the flow of wealth transfers either as an aggregate in national currency or as a ratio to national income, and often only one of the two. We do not convert one into the other, because doing so would require adopting a national income denominator that may differ from the one used by the authors; we publish what the source publishes. This is why the availability of `agg` and `rto` varies across sources in Table 7. Second, monetary aggregates are always reported in national currency and in nominal terms, with no adjustment for inflation. Where a series spans a change of currency — a redenomination, or the adoption of the euro — the values referring to the earlier period are converted, so that the series is expressed in the currency currently in force over its entire length and contains no unit break. A long `agg` series is therefore internally consistent, but it remains a nominal series: it is not comparable across countries without conversion, and its growth over a long historical period reflects price dynamics as much as the growth of the transferred wealth itself. For long-run and cross-country comparisons, the ratio to national income (`rto`) is the appropriate measure.

It is also important to note that when a source provides multiple estimates for the same series, reflecting alternative assumptions about mortality differentials, the treatment of gifts, or the valuation of assets, we select only one of these values, typically the benchmark estimate as defined in the underlying research.

Finally, where a country is covered by more than one source, we do not merge or splice the resulting series into a single time series. Different sources rest on different records and different estimation choices, and a spliced series would conceal a methodological break rather than resolve it. The series are published side by side under their respective `source` identifiers, and the Methodological Tables provide the information needed to decide which one is appropriate for a given purpose.

1.5.3 Step 3: Testing and Appending

After making sure the acquired estimates follow our formatting standards, we run a set of consistency checks and tests before we append them to the Inheritance Trends database. Besides the general formatting and duplication checks, these include substantive tests: that the ratio to national income lies in a plausible range and that its aggregate counterpart, where both are available, is consistent with it; that the flow of inheritances and gifts (`etnweg`) is not smaller than the flow of inheritances alone (`etnwea`) for the same country, year, source, and flow type; and that the average effective tax rate (`averat`) lies between zero and one and is consistent with the tax revenue and the flow of transfers from which it is derived.

1.6 Methodological Tables

The **Methodological Tables** summarize for each source, among other things: the type of data used, where the work sources its data, the definition of the transfers covered, the methods of estimation, how different assets are valued, how specific types of assets and transfers are treated, any adjustments made to the data, important underlying assumptions, and more. We provide a brief description of the content of the **Methodological Tables** in Table 8. Fields that do not apply to a given source are left empty.

Table 8: Methodological Tables - Content Description

Field name	Field description
Legend	The name of the source.
Period covered and data points	The range from the first to last year included in the series published in the warehouse; the precise years and/or quarters for which data points are available; the total number of years and/or quarters containing data points.
Data type	A categorization of the data type(s) used in the series published in the warehouse.
Inequality indicators	The precise inequality measures covered in the series. See the description of the varcode (vartype) for more information on these measures.
Data sources used in the research	A list of all data sources used in the estimation of wealth inequality and the year(s) they provide data for. Note that not all of these data sources are necessarily relevant to the specific series we publish in the database. Full citation information for these sources is not typically included in the references section, and should instead be located from the source itself.
Unit of analysis	The unit of analysis of the series published in the warehouse. See the description of the varcode (dashboard-specific) for details.
Definition of wealth	The precise definition of wealth underlying the wealth inequality estimates provided by the source.
Method of estimation	A brief summary of the estimation method of the series published in the warehouse.
Method of estimation (detailed)	A more detailed explanation (when applicable) of the estimation method of the series published in the warehouse.
Valuation of assets	How specific assets and liabilities have been valued.
Treatment of private pensions	Whether any private pensions are included in the wealth definition, and if applicable, how they have been valued.
Treatment of public pensions	Whether any public pensions are included in the wealth definition, and if applicable, how they have been valued.
Treatment of life insurance	Whether any life insurance benefits are included in the wealth definition, and if applicable, how they have been valued.
Treatment of household and personal goods (e.g., vehicles, boats, aircraft, jewelry, antiques, works of art, collections)	Whether any valuables and consumer goods are included in the definition of wealth, and if applicable, how they have been valued.
Treatment of foreign wealth holdings	Whether any assets held abroad are included in the wealth definition, and if applicable, how they have been valued.
Treatment of debt	Which types of liabilities are included in the wealth definition, and if applicable, how they have been valued.
Adjustments to data	An explanation of any significant adjustments made to the raw data.
Distributional estimates aligned with national account aggregates	Whether the wealth estimate has been brought into alignment with the reference country's national accounts wealth aggregates.
Total population estimate and source	The manner and source of the reference population estimate underlying the series.
Total wealth estimate and source	The manner and source of the aggregate wealth estimate underlying the series.
References	A bibliography for the sources cited parenthetically in the table's analysis (i.e., not necessarily those listed in the data sources used in the research section). Any important references that are called out by title in the analysis (such as appendices, data files, or a working paper version of the source) are listed first, with their reference information and any downloadable files being available at their hyperlinked entry in the Data Sources Library.

1.7 Additional Information on the Inheritance Trends Section

For additional information about the Inheritance Trends section, we refer the reader to the Appendix of this Documentation, where we provide a list of all sources included in the Inheritance Trends database, country-specific information on the coverage of the database, and additional information on the precise treatment of selected sources (Section ??).